

A bronze stage studded with golden performances

From Annu Rani's winning throw to Murali Sreeshankar's big leap, India **made its mark** at the inaugural World Athletics Continental Tour Bronze.

Y. B. Sarangi

sarangi.y@thehindu.co.in

Performances by seasoned javelin thrower Annu Rani, ace long jumper Murali Sreeshankar and promising sprinter Animesh Kujur were among the major highlights of India's first-ever World Athletics Continental Tour Bronze event at the Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar on August 10.

With very different backstories this season, these athletes have performed consistently in events across the world.

Annu spent three weeks training in Europe, ending her stint with a season-best throw of 62.59m in Poland. Within three days, and after travelling from a different time zone and cooler climate, she defied jet lag to produce two 61m-plus throws, including her winning effort of 62.01m on her fourth attempt.

For the 32-year-old, a few 60m-plus throws after more than a year — since winning the Asian Games gold — were a welcome confidence boost.

She also found encouragement in the atmosphere at the Kalinga Stadium, with spectators in the stands behind her spurring her on. She did not disappoint the young fans.

One bizarre moment came when Annu's cheering supporters kept the warmed-up men's 100m finalists waiting on the blocks for eight minutes. The delay was caused by concerns that the sprinters might miss the starting gun amid the noise.

Placed 30th on the Road to Tokyo rankings and set to compete in her fifth World Championships (the most by any Indian javelin thrower), Annu thanked her fans for their support and spoke of her technical focus ahead of the Worlds in Japan from September 13.

"When I throw, it's usually at a high angle. I'll have to keep it front-on. The other area is my run-up — I'll have to make it fast and smooth," said Annu, a two-time Worlds finalist.

Away from the spotlight, Sreeshankar thrived at his favourite venue — the place where he first crossed the 8m mark in 2018. In his comeback year, after missing the Paris Olympics due to a knee injury requiring surgery, the Kerala jumper has put in several impressive performances, including an 8.05m jump in Pune, both at home and abroad.

In the men's javelin, Sri Lanka's Rumesh Tharanga (86.50m — better than the direct Worlds qualification mark of 85.50m) and Sumedha